prime minister as their office does not derive any from the Constitution or legislation. The national security adviser is not answerable to parliament and the position is considered superfluous by those averse to greater executive privilege within a parliamentary system. ‘The cabinet secretary is a bureaucrat and the national security adviser is a political appointee,’ observed one retired civil servant, explaining why the job might have been created. ‘You can get the political appointee to do what they want; the cabinet secretary goes by the rules,’ he added.[51]

The Indian civil service’s culture of jealously guarding its turf has resulted in classic stovepipe decision making. Foreign policy in the contemporary world involves dealing with myriad issues ranging from climate change to trade, defence and energy. This means the involvement of what is termed in Indian bureaucratic parlance ‘the line ministries’. The Ministry of External Affairs must increasingly consult the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), Ministry of Defence (MoD), Ministry of Finance (MoF), Ministry of Environment and Forests (MoEF), Ministry of Science and Technology, the Atomic Energy Commission and Ministry of Commerce. Normally, the ministry concerned is the driver of policy whenever international issues relate to its sphere. Policy proposals go to the prime minister’s office or the Cabinet Committee on Security for approval after an inter-ministerial process.

Sometimes the nature of India’s relationship with a specific country makes a ministry other than the Ministry of External Affairs salient in relations with it. The Ministry of Finance always has a say in dealings with Japan because Japan is one of India’s largest aid donors. With a potential civil nuclear deal in the offing, the Department of Atomic Energy is also weighing in heavily in bilateral ties with Japan. Similarly, the presence of a large diaspora and the extent of energy ties makes ministries of energy and overseas Indian affairs significant players in dealing with Gulf Arab states.